

Ask any young person in Nairobi where "home" is, and watch their brain perform a quick, complicated calculation.

If you live here, home is supposed to be the apartment where you pay rent, keep your shoes, and argue with the caretaker about water pressure on a Tuesday morning. But if you tell an elder you live in Roysambu, South B, Kilimani, or Kasarani, they will look at you with deep, patient pity and ask, *"No, Kwenyu ni wapi?"*

They mean upcountry. They mean *shags*.

They mean the place with the red dust, the specific smell of woodsmoke in the morning, and the corrugated iron roof that makes rain sound like a personal conversation.

The hilarious reality for a lot of young people now, though, is that we rarely go to shags. Shags has become this distant, mythical concept we mostly visit during mandatory family events, weddings, or December when our parents basically force us into the car like hostages. We grow up in the city, or we move here early, and shags can feel like a foreign country where the Wi-Fi is questionable, the cows look at you like they know you don't belong, and your grandmother judges you for sleeping past 6:00 a.m.

I once heard someone at a coffee shop in Westlands complaining to her friend, *"I went to shags for three days and my back hurts from sitting on those wooden chairs. Plus, everyone kept asking me what I do for work, and how do you explain 'social media manager' to a woman who has spent sixty years farming tea?"*

It's funny, but it's real. You stand in the compound in shags, looking at the hills, and you realize that while this is your history, it isn't always where your heart currently sleeps. You feel like a tourist in your own lineage, standing in a living room filled with old photos of yourself in oversized primary school uniforms, trying to connect with a past that doesn't quite fit your present.

Yet, if you're honest, there's a weird, irresistible magic to shags that you can't find anywhere in Nairobi.

It's the absolute, shocking quiet.

In the city, silence doesn't exist; even at 2:00 a.m., there's a distant hum of traffic, a neighbor's subwoofer vibrating through the floor, or a security guard blowing a whistle down the street. But in shags, when night falls, the quiet is so thick and heavy it almost feels like a physical object. The air tastes completely different; crisp, cold, and fresh, without the diesel exhaust of Thika Road or the dust of construction sites. You step outside at dawn, breathe in that cool air,

look at the endless green, and for a few minutes, your lungs remember what they were actually made for. It's an unbothered, grounding kind of peace.

So you pack your bags, jump back on the bus, and head back to the city, carrying a piece of that quiet with you.

Except... Nairobi doesn't always feel like home either.

You return to your apartment, unlock the door, and look around. You realize you've paid three months' deposit, bought a nice rug, and put up fairy lights, but the moment the landlord sends that aggressive 1st-of-the-month WhatsApp message, the illusion shatters. You realize you're just a glorified tenant renting sixty square meters of concrete in a city that doesn't care if you live or die. You can live in a house for three years and still feel like you're just housesitting for a landlord who might decide to raise the rent by twenty percent next month.

So you end up caught floating in the strange, uncomfortable middle: too urban for shags, too temporary for the city, belonging everywhere and nowhere all at once.

The truth is, we spend half our lives confusing real estate with belonging. We buy furniture, hang pictures, and sign lease agreements, thinking that if we accumulate enough physical proof of residence, we will eventually feel settled. But brick and mortar are just containers. You can own a house with four bedrooms, granite countertops, and a double lock on the front door, and still walk through the rooms feeling like an intruder in your own life. You can be surrounded by your own possessions and still feel deeply homesick for a place you can't even name.

Because home was never meant to be a set of coordinates on a map.

Home is an emotional border control where you finally get to take off your armor.

Think about what it takes to navigate a city like Nairobi. It requires a very specific, high-maintenance survival mode. You walk down the street with a brisk, purpose-driven pace. You keep your bag zipped tight against your chest, your eyes alert, and your emotional customs officer on high duty. You learn to speak with a smooth, polished competence at work, to laugh at the right jokes, and to answer "I'm good" before anyone can notice the fatigue behind your eyes.

A friend of mine told me recently, *"I didn't realize how exhausted I was until I got off the matatu, climbed the four flights of stairs to my house, and just sat down on the cold concrete step right outside my door. I had my keys in my hand, but I just couldn't bring myself to unlock*

*it. I sat there in the dark hallway for twenty minutes with my bag on my lap because I couldn't face the thought of stepping inside and having to perform 'being okay' for an empty room."*

That hit me hard. Because we spend the entire day performing the role of an adult who has everything completely under control. We act like we aren't bothered by the traffic, the inflation, the unanswered messages, or the slow, creeping anxiety of trying to build a life from scratch.

So when you finally cross a threshold, whether it's an apartment door, a quiet bolt ride(if you're lucky), or a dimly lit living room and your shoulders drop two inches from your ears, *that* is home.

Home is the exact place where you stop performing.

It's the environment where you don't have to curate your personality to be tolerable. You can be grumpy, quiet, unpolished, and entirely uninteresting, and the space doesn't demand an apology from you. It doesn't ask you to justify why you're tired; it simply holds you while you rest. It's where you don't have to be the funny friend, the responsible firstborn, or the high-achieving professional. You just get to be a human being whose battery is at three percent.

And if we're being completely honest, the best kind of home rarely has a foundation built of concrete.

Sometimes, weirdly enough, home becomes a person.

It happens so quietly you don't even notice it at first. One day, they are just a stranger with a name and a phone number. A few months later, your entire internal map has rearranged itself around them. You realize that being in the same room with them gives you the exact same feeling as taking off a pair of tight shoes at the end of a twelve-hour day.

It's the weird, terrifying realization that their presence has become your actual geography. You can be sitting in a chaotic, overcrowded restaurant, or stuck in a soul-crushing traffic jam on Ngong Road while it's pouring rain, but if they are sitting next to you, the chaos stays on the outside of the glass. They become your human shock absorber.

It's the friend whose house you can walk into without knocking, heading straight to the kitchen to open their fridge like you helped pay for the groceries.

It's the specific, instant relief of hearing a familiar voice on the phone when the rest of your day has been an absolute disaster.

It's the person whose presence doesn't require you to be clever or entertaining. The person whose silence feels like a warm blanket rather than an impending test.

I met someone a while back who told me the story of how she knew her partner was "her person." She said she had a terrible panic attack in the middle of the night, the kind where you can't breathe and your brain is convinced the world is ending. She didn't have to explain anything. He didn't offer toxic positivity, he didn't tell her to calm down, and he didn't try to fix it. He just sat on the floor with her, brought her a glass of cold water, and stayed there in the dark until her breathing slowed down.

She told me, *"In that moment, I realized I didn't care where we lived or what city we were in. As long as he was there, I was safe."*

That is the strange absurdity of love and connection. You build all these physical structures, you sign leases, pay rent, buy locksets, and then a single human being walks in and quietly replaces the entire floor plan. Safety stops being an architectural feature and turns into a person who knows the worst, messiest parts of your story and hasn't changed the locks on you. There's also a quiet grief in realizing that places, and people, that used to feel like home don't always stay that way.

You visit your childhood bedroom, and suddenly the walls feel too close, the memories feel like someone else's life, and you realize you can't sleep in that bed anymore without feeling like you're trying to wear clothes you outgrew in high school. You meet up with an old friend from back in the day, hoping for that familiar warmth, only to spend two hours navigating awkward silences, forcing laughs, and realizing the only thing you still have in common is nostalgia.

It hurts, but it's a necessary kind of pain. It means you're evolving. It means you are no longer willing to settle for spaces that demand you shrink just to fit through the door. It forces you to realize that home isn't something you just inherit by default; it's something you actively build. You build it out of the boundary lines you set to protect your peace. You build it out of the playlist you listen to on full volume in your kitchen on a Sunday evening while making dinner. You build it out of the decision to stop letting people sit at your table when they bring chaos to your living room. You build it every time you choose safety over drama, and clarity over confusion.

We spend so much time grieving the places we used to live, or chasing the dream of a perfect future house with a compound and a gate, that we miss the tiny homes we build along the way. Home is the shared joke in the middle of a chaotic day.

It's the quiet cup of tea brewed exactly how you like it without you having to ask.

It's the person who texts, *"Let me know when you get there,"* and actually stays awake until you do. It's the person who will sense a shift in your tone even through a text message, read between two dry sentences, and ask, *'What do you need right now?'* It's sending a single, vague, punctuation-free text at 4:00 p.m. and having them reply instantly with, *'I'm coming over, do you want food or silence?'*

It's sitting on a worn-out sofa with someone, eating takeaway Smokies and chips, laughing until your stomach hurts about something stupid that happened years ago.

It's stepping out into the cold, crisp morning air in shags and realizing that the world can actually be quiet if you let it.

We don't need a grand estate to feel grounded. We just need spaces and people that make the world feel a little less loud, a little less demanding, and a lot more forgiving.

Because at the end of the day, an address is just where the postman delivers your bills.

But home? Home is wherever your nervous system finally feels safe enough to put down its weapons, take a deep breath, and say...

*"I'm here. I can rest now."*

So tell me... when was the last time you were somewhere or with someone, and realized you didn't have to pretend anymore?

Leave a response below. It's completely anonymous, and I'd love to read your story. Or better, drop into my dm.